



Linguist on the loose: adventures and misadventures in fieldwork

by Lyle Campbell, Edinburgh, Edinburgh University Press, 2022, pp. xviii + 286, \$110.00 (hardback), ISBN 978 1-4744-9414-4, \$19.95 (paperback), ISBN 978 1-4744-9415-1

Norbert Francis

To cite this article: Norbert Francis (2024) Linguist on the loose: adventures and misadventures in fieldwork, Journal of Multilingual and Multicultural Development, 45:10, 4593-4595, DOI: [10.1080/01434632.2023.2168908](https://doi.org/10.1080/01434632.2023.2168908)

To link to this article: <https://doi.org/10.1080/01434632.2023.2168908>



Published online: 16 Jan 2023.



Submit your article to this journal [↗](#)



Article views: 59



View related articles [↗](#)



View Crossmark data [↗](#)

thus lends itself to use in various courses and at various levels. At a research level, Martyn's work will interest specialists across the various sub-fields it covers – from language education, policy and practice to second-language learning, sociolinguistics and ethnolinguistics – with notable attention to detail and methodology. The presentation of different types of data and analysis within an ethnolinguistic approach is especially useful for those looking for relevant practical guidance. The opening chapters reflect the author's vast knowledge across wide-ranging areas and themes, and readers will appreciate her ability to draw the background material together in a cogent and cohesive manner.

Situated in an Irish secondary-school context prior to the introduction of 'Languages Connect: Ireland's Strategy for Foreign Languages in Education 2017–2026', the findings present learners' experiences with foreign-language learning, with particular regard to language choices, perceptions of the role of language(s), and learner investment in the context of identities and gender. While discussion of these matters draws on short and specific excerpts from the interviews, one wonders how the data might throw light on other relevant issues. Readers may want to know more about the interweavings among the different data types and student characteristics; they may also be curious about the generalisability of the findings beyond the specific school chosen here. This may provoke more comparative research across different types and locations of schools, and involving participants at different ages.

In sum, while Martyn's findings pre-date the 'Languages Connect' strategy, they show that learner experiences in relation to gender and identity cannot be overlooked as Ireland seeks to implement various facets of that strategy. The book is thus a milestone in its contribution here – and not only in the Irish context. Its innovative case-study approach will be of interest to all those involved in language education.

Publisher: Multilingual Matters, Elinor Robertson elinor@multilingual-matters.com; Florence McClelland flo@multilingual-matters.com; Laura Longworth laura@multilingual-matters.com

Martin Howard
University College Cork

 m.howard@ucc.ie  <http://orcid.org/0000-0003-3985-6554>

© 2023 Martin Howard
<https://doi.org/10.1080/01434632.2023.2168907>



Linguist on the loose: adventures and misadventures in fieldwork, by Lyle Campbell, Edinburgh, Edinburgh University Press, 2022, pp. xviii + 286, \$110.00 (hardback), ISBN 978 1-4744-9414-4, \$19.95 (paperback), ISBN 978 1-4744-9415-1

In modern times, the onset and development of language erosion/replacement typically involves bilingual or multilingual contact and usually cross-cultural interaction, for which reason readers of *JMMD* will be interested in the problems of collaboration between communities and researchers. Campbell presents here a guide for fieldwork based on his extensive experience, mainly in the Americas. In fact, the overriding theme of the memoir has to do with language documentation in the service of preservation, an objective that is actually much more complex than it might seem. We are reminded that overriding social and economic factors drive language change, historical developments in which linguists and educators play a peripheral role.

The first four chapters show how the goals of scientific investigation, if implemented correctly, come to be entirely compatible with those of documentation/preservation, how there is no inherent conflict of interest or cross-purpose. Important theoretical claims, about the limits of variation, for

instance – the ‘full range’ (43) within the linguistic domain – deal with what are possible and impossible properties of human language as a cognitive system. Chapter 3 gives a number of good examples. While the accurate description of the grammar of a group of endangered languages is of obvious theoretical importance, that same description serves the objective of documenting them for the purpose of creating a usable corpus for study – by native speakers and, especially, for learners with less than complete competence. In the end, only the speech community itself has the long-term core resources for constructing and using this corpus. As is made evident from the first chapters of the book, the objective remains important even when no native speakers or active second-language learners remain. Documentation then preserves the linguistic and cultural heritage of the community, guarding its patrimony and that of the plurilingual nation to which it belongs. The goals of research, documentation and preservation are in principle entirely compatible.

The next three chapters are full of sound advice for implementing a successful field study that also contributes to documentation. The question of measured and verifiable results of language revitalisation is properly deferred to a difficult and much longer discussion, as alluded to above. Three representative topics from these chapters stand out. First is the politics of orthography: the perennial disputes about script and spelling among academics and language-revitalisation activists are often, unfortunately, about concerns unrelated to the easily resolved problems of language-writing interface. As Chapter 5 points out, linguists working on documentation and preservation usually have no interest in taking sides here. Likewise, linguists need to remember that taking sides in political conflict in communities of which they are not members is – as a rule – simply not responsible. This rule applies with even greater force in situations of organised crime-related violence. When matters begin to get out of hand, those with passports will be on the first flight back to campus. All of us remember cases in which our fieldwork colleagues have suffered from criminality. Decisions about the value of data collection in situations where collaboration puts local consultants in danger ought not to be hard to make.

A third topic, cross-cultural understanding and misunderstanding, deserves its own volume. As they carefully study the available anthropological literature, fieldworkers planning research in a new community must control their expectations and maintain a strong scepticism about claims regarding difference – at the same time as preparing for the inevitable miscommunication arising from mismatches in the pragmatic system. Extended systems of honorifics and cultural norms regarding sex/gender relations are very serious matters. They remain important even (perhaps especially) when fieldworker and consultant share the same national language, where miscommunication is least expected. The default setting in this domain is that assumptions should be suspended until confirmed or disconfirmed, and that maximum discretion and modesty are required. The possibility of miscommunication surrounding ceremony and religion, which may involve prejudice and seemingly extreme and irrational disposition, must never be underestimated. Recommendations here apply most critically in face-to-face interaction, less so in transactions at a distance that benefit from time and deliberate monitoring. This is not to imply, of course, that the latter are not also important.

Campbell’s discussion of the problems in finding and working with language consultants reveals an interesting dilemma born of a contradiction – the progressive erosion of language ability coinciding with growing loyalty to and admiration of the language. Contemporary candidate consultants may overstate their true competence, when in the past they had done just the opposite. I am reminded of a public meeting, some years ago, in a city adjacent to a large Nahuatl-speaking region. During the discussion a middle-aged gentleman recited a long poem from the classical period, impeccably executed. After the meeting the young members of our project rushed over to greet him, only to learn that he could not provide a grammatical reply. It was both a moving occasion and an indication of things to come – how far-reaching being one of the themes that the final chapter brings to our attention.

The author’s interesting account unfortunately suffers from a foreword that is largely centred on a spectacularly uninformed critique of the theoretical proposals associated with Chomsky’s hypothesis of Universal Grammar (UG). It is claimed, without explanation or evidence, that UG is actually

an impediment to the endangered-languages research programme and to practical efforts on behalf of language communities. Given the seriousness of the tasks that communities and linguists face, the relevant passage requires a rectification. The foreword suggests that for UG-orientated researchers (called Chomsky's 'acolytes' by author Wade Davis), the study of the vocabulary and morphology/syntax of languages, and the compilation of dictionaries and language-specific grammars, is 'a completely pointless exercise' (xiii). To the contrary, hundreds of linguists and their students work on this kind of description, analysis and documentation from the various tendencies within the two major currents in the field (UG-orientated and Usage-based), probably in roughly equal numbers. In fact, description and analysis from each camp, especially in work on endangered languages, complement those of the other and, indeed, the work of all interested researchers. How a difference in theoretical perspective regarding the properties of the faculty of language or linguistic ability can become an obstacle to language preservation is never explained. The attempts at justifying the accusations – that UG is not interested 'in what [distinguishes] languages', or that it claims that 'culture [has] no role to play in the study of language' or that there is 'an immutable set of rules' (xiii) encoded in the brain – are simply misleading distortions.

Chapter 8 tries to put this unfortunate misunderstanding into perspective with a short history and overview of the field. In addition, the concluding chapter expands upon a closely related point:

It is just not accurate to separate linguists into fieldworkers/documentary

linguists vs. theoreticians, those who follow formal approaches.

Many well-known formal linguists are also fieldworkers and have

participated in language documentation, and many who do

fieldwork and language documentation have been committed to

and have contributed also to aspects of formal theory. Putting a wedge

between theorists and fieldwork/documentary linguists does linguistics

no service. For some linguists, theoretical motives are what

drive their concern for documentation ... they document endangered

languages in order to discover more about the full range of what is

possible and impossible in human languages, in order to pursue the

goal of linguistic theory of understanding universal grammar. (244)

This inclusive approach to documentation and analysis leads to greater sharing of resources among investigators from different schools and theoretical backgrounds. It also contributes to a more productive collaboration with the speakers of endangered languages. The procedures of reliable description are, in fact, largely shared within the field, providing a common platform for application and implementation in community fieldwork projects and allowing us to put secondary differences aside. Participants and observers may be surprised to notice that, depending on the domain of language ability (second-language learning and literacy, for example) there often exists broad common ground on foundational concepts that underlie applied research objectives.

Norbert Francis
Northern Arizona University
 norbert.francis@nau.edu

© 2023 Norbert Francis
<https://doi.org/10.1080/01434632.2023.2168908>

